

When a Parent Dies - Printable Checklists and Worksheets

From *When a Parent Dies* by Anne Merriweather (Oro Enigma Publishing). Print as many copies as you need.

These are working sheets. Keep them all in one folder with the death certificates and the estate account statements, and you will be able to answer any question anyone asks you a year from now.

THE DEATH CERTIFICATE LOG

Treat certified copies like cash. Most organisations keep the one you send.

Ordered: _____ copies on ____ / ____ / _____ **Cost per copy:** \$ _____

#	Sent to	Date sent	Returned?
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			
8			
9			
10			
11			
12			

13			
14			
15			

Check on arrival: name spelling - date of birth - Social Security number - place of death - marital status - parents' names - cause of death. An error is far easier to fix now than in month six.

THE ASSET-SEARCH WORKSHEET

The last column is the one that decides whether you need probate. See Chapters 9 and 10.

Account / asset	Institution	Approx. value	Beneficiary named?	Joint?	In trust?

Where to look: the mail, for a full year - the last two tax returns - the computer and the phone, for paperless accounts that generate no mail at all - the address book, for a lawyer or broker - unidentified keys - your state's unclaimed property database - the NAIC life policy locator - the Pension Benefit Guaranty Corporation - savings bonds.

The arithmetic that decides everything

Total of all assets: \$ _____

Less: everything with a **named beneficiary** - \$ _____

Less: everything held **jointly with survivorship** -
\$ _____

Less: everything **in a funded trust** - \$ _____

= The probate estate: \$ _____

Now look up your state's small-estate threshold and compare. If the probate estate is below it, you very probably do not need a full probate.

My state's small-estate limit: \$ _____ **Checked on:**
____ / ____ / _____ **Source:** _____

THE ESTATE INVENTORY

Values are **as at the date of death**, not today. This figure sets the new tax basis - see Chapter 19.

Item	Description	Date-of-death value	How valued

Get a written appraisal for real estate, jewellery, art, firearms and collections. For the house this is the single most valuable few hundred dollars you will spend.

THE EXECUTOR'S RUNNING ACCOUNT

Every dollar in and out of the estate account. Nothing else goes through it, and estate money never touches your own account.

Date	Description	In	Out	Balance	Receipt filed?

This sheet becomes the final accounting. It is also the complete answer to any sibling who asks where the money went.

THE WHO-TO-NOTIFY CHECKLIST

Organisation	Date told	Spoke to	Reference	Done
Social Security				
Medicare / health insurance				
Medicaid				
Veterans Administration				
Employer				
Pension provider(s)				
Home insurer (vacancy - do first)				
Car insurer				
Landlord / HOA				
Bank(s)				
Brokerage(s)				
Life insurer(s)				
Mortgage company				
Credit cards				

Equifax				
Experian				
TransUnion				
Motor vehicle agency				
Utilities (keep running)				
Phone (keep for now)				
Post office - forwarding				
Lawyer / accountant				
Subscriptions, memberships				

THE SIBLING DIVISION WORKSHEET

Agree the method **before** anything leaves the house, and photograph every room first.

Method chosen (circle one): round-robin / coloured stickers / points / lots for clashes / sell and split

Who is choosing:

Order drawn (reverse each round): 1 _____ 2 _____ 3 _____ 4 _____

Specific bequests in the will - already decided, not available to choose

Item	Left to	Confirmed against the will

The rounds

Round	Who chose	Item
1		

1		
1		
2		
2		
2		
3		
3		
3		

Clashes, and how they were settled

Item	Who wanted it	Settled by	Outcome

Before you start: get the valuable things appraised. **For everyone:** have the photograph albums scanned and give every sibling the complete set - it is the one thing nobody fights over and everybody wants.

THE FIRST-YEAR TIMELINE

When	What	Date done
Week 1	Funeral home; dependants cared for	
Week 1	Order 10-15 death certificates	
Week 1	Tell home insurer - property unoccupied	
Week 1	Social Security; employer; pension	
Week 1	Find the will; file with court if required	
Weeks 2-4	Banks, insurers, utilities, DMV, VA	
Weeks 2-4	Flag all three credit bureaus	
Weeks 2-4	Build the asset inventory	
Weeks 2-4	Do the probate arithmetic	
Weeks 2-4	Reverse mortgage, if any - short deadline	
Month 2-3	Apply to probate court; get letters	
Month 2-3	EIN; open the estate account	
Month 2-3	Creditor notice published and sent	
Month 2-3	Date-of-death appraisal on real estate	

Months 3-9	Claim insurance, pensions, retirement accounts	
Months 3-9	Divide personal property	
Months 3-9	Monthly update to all beneficiaries	
By 15 April	Final Form 1040	
By 15 April	Form 1041, if \$600+ estate income	
Months 9-18	Pay valid claims in statutory order	
Months 9-18	Final accounting; releases signed	
Months 9-18	Distribute - hold back a reserve	
Months 9-18	Discharge; keep every record	

Pay no beneficiary until the creditor period has closed and the taxes are settled. If you do and a valid claim arrives afterwards, you may have to find the money yourself.

AND WHEN IT IS OVER - YOUR OWN AFFAIRS

The hour that matters most, while it is still vivid. Tick them off.

- ☐ A will
- ☐ Durable power of attorney for finances
- ☐ Health care directive, with a named proxy
- ☐ **Check every beneficiary form** - retirement accounts, life insurance, POD accounts. These override the will
- ☐ Write the list: accounts, institutions, insurers, lawyer, where the deed is, where the passwords are
- ☐ Say what you want for your funeral, in writing, to the person who will arrange it
- ☐ If your other parent is still living: ask where the documents are

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